COUNTER SALES ESSENTIALS

Counter Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 4: Objections and Hard Moments at the Counter

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1 · Day 4: Objections and Hard Moments at the Counter

How to Use This Guide

Today is about the moments that decide whether a counter sale ends well: the price objection, the request for a discount, the return, the complaint. Read each section once, then do the practice. Write your answers before you look at the model answers at the end.

You do not need a counter job to do this. Every exercise has a no-job-yet option: role-play with a friend, record yourself on your phone, or use the fictional customers in this guide.

This guide is Day 4 of 5. It builds on what you learned about opening a counter sale, the First-Contact Standard, and recommending and adding what the job needs. Today you learn two tools: the Mandatory Pause and A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework for objections.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know why customers push back at the counter, and the three steps of A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework: Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition.

Attitude: You will see a price objection as information about fear, not as an attack on your product or on you.

Skill: You will be able to handle a price objection using A.R.T. as one chain, with the Mandatory Pause before you answer.

Upskill: You will be able to answer a discount request you cannot grant with a calm, polite no, and keep the customer with you.

Why Customers Push Back

A customer at your counter says, "That's too expensive." Your body may react before your mind does. You may feel the urge to defend, to drop the price, or to talk faster. That urge is normal. It is also the wrong move.

Most pushback is not really about the number. It comes from three fears.

First, the fear of paying too much. The customer cannot see what you can see. They do not know what the part costs elsewhere, or whether the cheaper version would have failed them next month. Their uncertainty sounds like a price complaint.

Second, the fear of being sold to. Nobody likes to feel steered. A customer who senses pressure will pull back, even if your product is right. This is the psychology of reactance, described by Brehm (1966): when people feel their freedom of choice is threatened, they push against it. Push harder and the customer pushes back harder.

Third, the wish to stay in control. At a counter, the customer chose to come to you. They want to leave feeling they made the decision, not that it was made for them.

When you understand these three fears, you stop hearing "no" as rejection. You hear it as a request for clarity and control. That changes how you answer. You stay calm. You do not defend features. You help the customer see what the decision actually costs them.

The same idea applies when a customer is upset about a return or a wrong part. They are not angry at you personally. They are protecting their time, their money or their plans for the job. Your job is to help them get back in control.

The Mandatory Pause

The Mandatory Pause (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Voss and Raz) is MEDJAY's name for a pause of a few seconds after a customer states a price objection or asks a hard question, before you say anything.

This is based on the effective pauses described by Voss and Raz in Never Split the Difference. The idea is simple. When a hard statement lands, most people rush to fill the gap. A rushed answer sounds nervous, defensive or eager. A calm pause sounds confident.

Try a practice example. A customer holds up a part and says, "That much? I can get it cheaper online." If you answer instantly with "Well, ours is better quality," the customer hears a salesperson defending themselves. If you pause, look at them calmly, and then say, "Tell me what you are comparing it to," they hear someone taking the question seriously. The pause made your answer land. It also gives you a moment to think.

The Mandatory Pause also protects you. In the pause you can check your own numbers, decide what you are allowed to offer, and choose your words. You are less likely to promise something you cannot deliver.

One more tool for the pause: your breathing. A slow breath out before you speak lowers your own tension and keeps your voice steady. Research on vocal confidence shows that a steady, confident voice influences how persuasive people find you (Guyer, Fabrigar, & Vaughan-Johnston, 2019). You do not need to be loud. You need to be calm.

Practice the pause out loud. Count to three in your head. Then begin. If your pause feels awkward to you, it probably feels like thoughtfulness to the customer.

A.R.T., MEDJAY's Own Framework for Objections

A.R.T. is MEDJAY's own framework for handling objections and concerns. It has three steps, always used together, in order.

A: Acknowledge. Label the customer's feeling, with no "but" after it. You name what they seem to feel: "You want to be sure you are not paying over the odds." You stop there. Adding "but" cancels the acknowledgment and restarts the argument.

R: Reframe. Shift the decision criterion from the visible cost to the cost of inaction. Do not defend features. Instead, help the customer see what happens if they make the wrong choice or delay. The customer was comparing price today. You help them compare the cost of the wrong part, a second trip, or a job delayed.

T: Transition. Ask a calibrated how or what question. Never a yes/no close, never a trade or concession. The question moves the conversation forward and hands control back to the customer.

Here is the whole chain in action.

Practice example: A customer at a paint counter says, "Thirty for a can of paint? The other brand is twenty." You pause, then say: "You want to make sure you are not paying for something you do not need. (Acknowledge) The number that matters most is often how many coats you have to buy and how long it lasts. A cheaper can that needs two extra coats and shows brush marks can cost you more in time and product. (Reframe) What does the wall need to look like when you are done? (Transition)"

Notice what happened. You did not defend the paint. You did not offer a discount. You changed what the customer is comparing, then asked a question that puts the choice back in their hands. That is A.R.T. as one chain, every time.

The same chain works for "I'll check somewhere else." Acknowledge: "You want to be sure you are getting the best deal." Reframe: "Checking is smart. What matters is whether the item is in stock today, fits the job, and comes with a return path if it does not." Transition: "What would make the difference for you: getting it today, or waiting to save a little?"

Use A.R.T. only for objections and concerns. It is not a greeting tool and not a way to close. You will learn the close on Day 5.

Discount Requests Within Your Authority

Sometimes the customer asks directly: "Can you do something on the price?" Before you answer, know your authority. Never promise a discount, price or exception outside it. If you are not sure what you may offer, say so honestly and check with the person who sets it. That is not a weakness. It protects the customer's trust and your job.

When you can offer nothing, use the Mandatory Pause, then a calm no with a reason and a path forward.

Practice example: "I understand you were hoping for a lower number. (Acknowledge) I am not able to move on the price today. What I can do is make sure you walk out with exactly what the job needs, so you are not buying twice. (Reframe) What else does the job need before you start? (Transition)"

When you do have some room, do not give it away for nothing. Trade, do not concede. Ask for something of equal value in return: a larger quantity, a faster decision, or taking a related item together.

A yes/no close such as "Shall I go ahead then?" is weak here. It invites a no. Use a calibrated question instead, as you did above.

Returns, Wrong Parts and Complaints

A customer arrives with a part that did not fit, or a receipt and a complaint. The queue is behind them. Here is what works.

Let them finish. Do not interrupt to explain what went wrong.

Acknowledge the feeling first, before any facts: "That is frustrating. You planned to have this done today."

Then find the facts. Ask what the job is, what they were trying to fit, and what happened. Take the return seriously. Your goal is that they leave calmer than they arrived.

Then fix what you can within your authority, and be clear about what you cannot do. If a refund, an exchange or an exception is beyond your authority, say so plainly and explain the next step.

When a customer is upset in front of a queue, you have two audiences: the person in front of you and everyone waiting. Handle the upset customer with your full attention, but acknowledge the queue out loud: "Thank you for waiting, I will be with you next." That one line lowers the tension for everyone. People tolerate a wait far better when they feel noticed (Maister, 1985).

Apply It in Your Role

If you already work at a counter: use your next price objection as a real practice round. Pause before you answer. Run the full A.R.T. chain. Note what the customer actually said and what they chose. Never write real names or account details.

If you do not have a counter job yet: stand at any counter as a customer this week and watch how staff handle a price question or a complaint. Notice who pauses, who defends, who stays calm. Then role-play the same scene with a friend playing the customer.

Run this drill three times with fictional objections: "Too expensive." "I can get it cheaper across town." "I'll think about it and check somewhere else." Time your pause, then run A.R.T. out loud.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you read the model answers.

1. A customer at a parts counter says, "That is more than I expected." What do you say?

2. A customer asks for a discount you are not allowed to give. What do you say?

3. A customer returns a part that did not fit and says loudly, "This is the second time you people gave me the wrong thing." There is a queue behind them. What do you say?

Key Takeaways

- Pushback is usually fear of paying too much, fear of being sold to, or the wish to stay in control. Answer the fear, not the words.
- Use the Mandatory Pause before you answer a price objection or a hard question. A few seconds of calm beats a fast answer.
- A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, is Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition, always as one chain. Never defend features and never offer a trade in the Transition.
- Never promise a discount outside your authority. A calm no with a reason and a path forward keeps the customer with you.
- With a complaint, let the customer finish, acknowledge first, then find the facts. Acknowledge the queue too.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Choose one option for each.

1. A customer says the price is too high. What is the first thing you do after they speak?
   - **A.** Explain every feature that justifies the price
   - **B.** Pause for a few seconds before answering
   - **C.** Offer a small discount to keep them
   - **D.** Tell them the cheaper option is poor quality
2. What is the correct order of A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework?
   - **A.** Reframe, Acknowledge, Transition
   - **B.** Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition
   - **C.** Transition, Acknowledge, Reframe
   - **D.** Acknowledge, Transition, Reframe
3. In the Reframe step, what are you shifting?
   - **A.** The customer's decision from the visible cost to the cost of inaction
   - **B.** The customer's attention from one product to a cheaper one
   - **C.** The conversation from the counter to the phone
   - **D.** The price to match a competitor
4. A customer asks for a discount you are not allowed to give. What is the best response?
   - **A.** Promise to ask your supervisor, then forget it
   - **B.** Offer a different discount you can approve
   - **C.** Pause, acknowledge, say plainly you cannot move today, then offer a clear next step
   - **D.** Say "Shall I just ring it up for you?"
5. An upset customer complains in front of a queue. What do you do?
   - **A.** Ask them to step aside so you can serve the queue first
   - **B.** Explain the return policy before they finish speaking
   - **C.** Match their tone so they know you take it seriously
   - **D.** Let them finish, acknowledge the feeling, then find the facts

Upskill Challenge

This week, record yourself on your phone running A.R.T. three times on the fictional objections below. Listen back and check two things: did you pause before answering, and did your Transition question avoid yes/no?

Objection 1: "That is too much for a phone case."

Objection 2: "I will just check the big store first."

Objection 3: "Can you knock something off the price?"

Then script your polite no to a discount you cannot give, and say it out loud until it sounds like your own words, not a script. Last, act out a complaint at a busy counter with a friend playing the upset customer and a second friend waiting in the queue. Aim for the customer leaving calmer than they arrived.

☐ Recorded three A.R.T. runs on my phone

☐ Paused before each answer

☐ Wrote my polite no and said it out loud

☐ Acted out one complaint with a queue waiting

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

1. "You were expecting a lower number. (Acknowledge) The part that fails early or does not fit is the one that really costs you, in time and a second trip. (Reframe) What is the job you are doing with it? (Transition)"

2. "I understand you were hoping for a lower price. (Acknowledge) I am not able to move on the price today. What I can do is make sure you leave with exactly what you need. (Reframe) What else does the job need before you start? (Transition)"

3. Let them finish. "That is frustrating, and I am sorry it happened twice. (Acknowledge) Let us sort out the right part so you are not making a third trip. (Reframe) What were you fitting it to? (Transition)" Then turn briefly to the queue: "Thank you for waiting, I will be with you next."

Quiz answers:

1. B. The Mandatory Pause keeps your answer calm and gives you time to choose your words.

2. B. A.R.T. is Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition, always in that order.

3. A. The Reframe moves the decision from visible cost to what doing nothing or choosing wrong will cost.

4. C. A calm no with a reason and a path forward keeps trust; promising what you cannot give, or a weak yes/no close, breaks it.

5. D. Letting them finish and acknowledging first lowers the tension for them and for everyone waiting.

References

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